

Atoms & Nuclear Radiation.

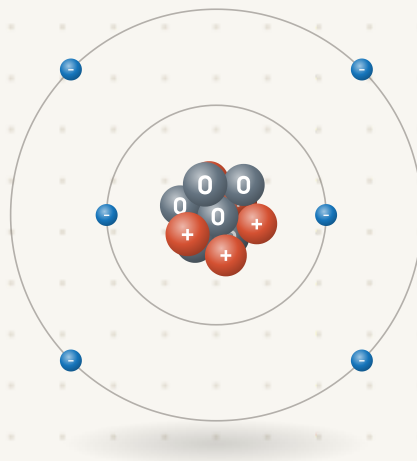
Lesson 06

Nuclear equations

Radium-226 decays and becomes radon, a completely different element. How can we predict exactly which nucleus it turns into?

IN THIS LESSON YOU WILL

- use the symbols for alpha, beta, gamma and neutron radiation
- balance a nuclear equation using mass numbers and atomic numbers
- work out the new nucleus after alpha or beta decay
- explain the effect of each decay on the mass and charge of the nucleus



NAME

CLASS

TEACHER

TARGET GRADE

How this booklet works.

This is the booklet for **Lesson 6** of the Atoms and Nuclear Radiation unit. It builds on the lessons before it; the “Do now” questions and the quick answers at the back help you check what you remember. Keep it: it is your classwork book *and* your revision guide.



DO NOW

Quick questions from earlier lessons. Remembering again is what makes it stick.



LEARN IT

Explanations, diagrams and worked examples. Read this again when you revise.



TRY IT

Practice that builds up: first with support, then on your own, then a challenge.



LAB

Record what you find in a simulation or a model experiment.



EXAM CORNER

AQA-style questions with a tip on how the marks are given.



REVISE IT

Summary, cover-and-answer questions and an “I can” check to colour in.



Revising at home? (1) Read the Learn it pages. (2) Cover them and answer the “Cover the page” questions in Revise it. (3) Check with the quick answers at the back. (4) Go through the matching slides in the teaching deck, and try the simulations.

● The route through the unit · this lesson is highlighted

01 Inside the atom

03 From plum pudding to the nucleus

05 Radioactive decay

07 Properties and uses of radiation

09 Half-life calculations

02 Isotopes and ions

04 Energy levels and the nucleus

06 Nuclear equations

Symbols for each radiation, balancing mass and atomic numbers · slides 24–27

08 Half-life and random decay

10 Contamination and irradiation

Teaching deck: panphy.app/gcsephy/decks/atoms-and-radiation · Simulations:

panphy.app/simulations/atomic_models.html and panphy.app/simulations/nuclear_decay.html

Nuclear equations.

AQA Physics 4.4.2.2 • Combined Science 6.4.2.2

BIG QUESTION

Radium-226 decays and becomes radon, a completely different element. How can we predict exactly which nucleus it turns into?

BY THE END YOU CAN

- use the symbols for alpha, beta, gamma and neutron radiation
- balance a nuclear equation using mass numbers and atomic numbers
- work out the new nucleus after alpha or beta decay
- explain the effect of each decay on the mass and charge of the nucleus

nuclear equation

parent nucleus

daughter nucleus

mass number

atomic number

balance

SLIDES AND SIMULATIONS

Teaching deck, slides 24–27

Alpha, beta and gamma equations, and the 'What changes?' table.

panphy.app/gcsephy/decks/atoms-and-radiation/#24

Nuclear Decay simulation

panphy.app/simulations/nuclear_decay.htm



RETRIEVE

Do now

From earlier lessons. No notes!

1

What is an alpha particle made of?

2

What happens in the nucleus in beta decay?

3

What is the unit of activity?



Balancing nuclear equations

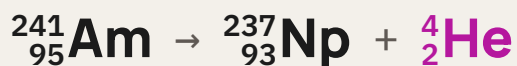
● Symbols for nuclear radiation

Emitted	Symbol	Mass number	Atomic number
Alpha particle	${}^4_2\text{He}$	decreases by 4	decreases by 2
Beta particle	${}^0_{-1}\text{e}$	no change	increases by 1
Gamma ray	γ	no change	no change
Neutron	${}^1_0\text{n}$	decreases by 1	no change

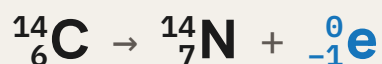
An electron has almost no mass, so its top number is 0. Its charge is -1 , so its bottom number is -1 . When a neutron (charge 0) turns into a proton (charge $+1$), the beta particle carries away the -1 : the charges still balance.

! In every nuclear equation, the **top numbers add up to the same total** on both sides, and so do the **bottom numbers**. If the atomic number changes, a **new element** forms.

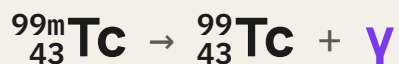
● The three equations from the slides



alpha • top: $241 = 237 + 4$ • bottom: $95 = 93 + 2$



beta • top: $14 = 14 + 0$ • bottom: $6 = 7 + (-1)$



gamma • the 'm' means the nucleus has extra energy • A and Z do not change

WORKED EXAMPLE

Radium-226, $^{226}_{88}\text{Ra}$, emits an alpha particle and becomes radon (Rn). Write the equation.

TOP $226 - 4 = 222$

BOTTOM $88 - 2 = 86$

NEW NUCLEUS $^{222}_{86}\text{Rn}$

**YOUR TURN**

Uranium-238, $^{238}_{92}\text{U}$, emits an alpha particle and becomes thorium (Th). Write the equation.

TOP

BOTTOM

NEW NUCLEUS

EQUATION

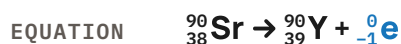
WORKED EXAMPLE

Strontium-90, $^{90}_{38}\text{Sr}$, emits a beta particle and becomes yttrium (Y). Write the equation.

TOP $90 - 0 = 90$

BOTTOM $38 + 1 = 39$

NEW NUCLEUS $^{90}_{39}\text{Y}$

**YOUR TURN**

Iodine-131, $^{131}_{53}\text{I}$, emits a beta particle and becomes xenon (Xe). Write the equation.

TOP

BOTTOM

NEW NUCLEUS

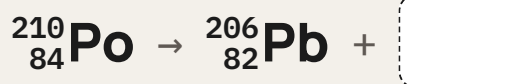
EQUATION



PRACTISE

Try it

- 1 **SUPPORTED** Fill in the missing particle. Check that the top and bottom numbers balance.



2

ON YOUR OWN

Fill in the missing nucleus. The element symbols are given.

*Po = polonium**Ba = barium**a helium-5 nucleus emits a neutron*

3

Name the type of decay in each equation.

Equation	Type of decay
${}_{19}^{40}\text{K} \rightarrow {}_{20}^{40}\text{Ca} + {}_{-1}^0\text{e}$	
${}_{92}^{238}\text{U} \rightarrow {}_{90}^{234}\text{Th} + {}_2^4\text{He}$	
${}_{43}^{99\text{m}}\text{Tc} \rightarrow {}_{43}^{99}\text{Tc} + \gamma$	

4

Complete the table to show the effect of each decay on the nucleus.

Radiation emitted	Effect on the mass of the nucleus	Effect on the charge of the nucleus
alpha		
beta		
gamma		

5

Explain what is wrong with Leo's statement.

Leo

In beta decay the nucleus loses an electron, so the mass number goes down by 1.

- 6 **CHALLENGE** Uranium-238, $^{238}_{92}\text{U}$, decays by alpha emission. The new nucleus then decays by beta emission, and the next one by beta emission again. Find the final nucleus. What do you notice?



AQA-STYLE

Exam corner

Write in full sentences. Show every step of a calculation.

Get the marks: Both numbers earn a mark. Check: top $212 = ? + 4$, bottom $83 = ? + 2$.

- 7 Bismuth-212, $^{212}_{83}\text{Bi}$, decays by alpha emission to form thallium (Tl). [2 marks]
Complete the nuclear equation.



- 8 Technetium-99m emits gamma radiation. Explain why the element does not change. [2 marks]



SUMMARY

- Symbols: alpha ${}^4_2\text{He}$, beta ${}^0_{-1}\text{e}$, gamma γ , neutron ${}^1_0\text{n}$.
- Top numbers balance; bottom numbers balance.
- Alpha: mass number – 4, atomic number – 2.
- Beta: mass number unchanged, atomic number + 1.
- Gamma: no change to either number.

COVER THE PAGE AND ANSWER

1 What is the symbol for a beta particle?

3 Which decay does not change the mass number or atomic number?

2 What happens to the atomic number in alpha decay?

4 Complete: ${}^{226}_{88}\text{Ra} \rightarrow ? + {}^4_2\text{He}$

I CAN...

write the symbols for alpha, beta, gamma and neutron radiation



balance a nuclear equation



find the new nucleus after alpha or beta decay



explain the effect of each decay on mass and charge



Toolkit.

The facts and methods you have met so far. Learn these: exam questions expect you to recall them without a data sheet.

The three particles

Lesson 1

Particle	Charge	Mass	Where
Proton	+1	1	nucleus
Neutron	0	1	nucleus
Electron	-1	very small	energy levels

Reading the symbol

Lesson 1

$${}^A_Z\text{X}$$
 e.g. ${}^{23}_{11}\text{Na}$

- Z, atomic number = protons
- A, mass number = protons + neutrons
- neutrons = A - Z · in an atom, electrons = Z
- Atom radius $\approx 1 \times 10^{-10}$ m; nucleus radius $< 1/10\,000$ of that

Isotopes and ions

Lesson 2

- **Isotopes**: same number of protons, different numbers of neutrons.
- **Positive ion**: an atom that has lost one or more outer electrons. The nucleus is unchanged.

Alpha scattering

Lesson 3

Observation	Conclusion
most straight through	mostly empty space
some deflected	positive centre
a very few bounced back	mass in a tiny centre

Models and energy levels

Lesson 4

- 1897 electron · 1904 plum pudding · 1911 nuclear · 1913 Bohr · 1932 neutron (Chadwick)
- **Absorb** EM radiation → higher level, further out.
- **Emit** EM radiation → lower level, closer in.

Nuclear radiation

Lesson 5

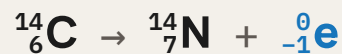
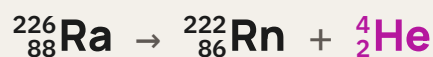
- Unstable nuclei decay at **random** to become more stable.
- **Activity**: decays per second, in becquerel (Bq). **Count rate**: decays recorded per second by a detector.
- α : $2p + 2n$ · β : fast electron, a neutron → proton · γ : EM radiation · n: a neutron

Nuclear equations

Lesson 6

Emitted	Symbol	Mass no.	Atomic no.
alpha	${}^4_2\text{He}$	- 4	- 2
beta	${}^0_{-1}\text{e}$	no change	+ 1
gamma	γ	no change	no change
neutron	${}^1_0\text{n}$	- 1	no change

Top numbers balance; bottom numbers balance.



REFERENCE

Key words from this lesson.

Learn the meaning and spelling. In exams, precise words earn marks: say “nucleus”, not “middle”, and “unstable nucleus”, not “unstable atom”.

Daughter nucleus · The new nucleus formed when a nucleus decays.

Nuclear equation · An equation showing a decay, in which the mass numbers and atomic numbers balance.

CHECK YOURSELF

Quick answers.

Answers to the “Do now” and “Cover the page” questions, so you can check yourself when revising. Answers to the longer questions are in the answer edition.

DO NOW

1. 2 protons and 2 neutrons (a helium nucleus).
2. A neutron turns into a proton, and a fast electron is emitted.
3. Becquerel (Bq).

COVER THE PAGE

1. ${}^0_{-1}\text{e}$
2. It decreases by 2.
3. Gamma emission.
4. ${}^{222}_{86}\text{Rn}$